

Twelfth century only — **1100–1199** — gives a very tight answer:

Aokigahara is physically present, but culturally almost mute. Fuji is not mute. The decisive twelfth-century transformation is that Fuji shifts from a feared eruption-mountain worshipped from below into a mountain entered by Buddhist ascetics. The key figure is 末代上人 / Matsudai Shōnin, and the key date is 1149.

So the root is not “suicide forest”. It is:

volcanic fear → ascetic entry → summit Buddhism → Fuji Shugendō.

Aokigahara later inherits some of the atmosphere of this Fuji world, but in the twelfth century the recorded charge is **upward to the summit**, not inward into the forest.

1. Physical Aokigahara in the twelfth century: young lava forest, not ancient deathscape

By 1100, Aokigahara had existed for only about 235 years after the 864–866 Jōgan eruption. The Fuji Sabo Office describes that eruption as the event that produced the Aokigahara lava; it says the lava is visible under the forest and along Saiko, Shōjiko and Motosuko, and identifies the 864–866 lava as 青木ヶ原溶岩. 

This matters because in the twelfth century Aokigahara is not “ancient primeval forest” in any absolute sense. It is a young post-eruption ecosystem growing over rough lava. Yamanashi’s own nature page says Aokigahara formed on the lava from the 864 eruption, has only around **10-plus cm of soil**, and supports trees whose roots spread over the lava rather than into deep earth.  『公式』富士の...

So the twelfth-century forest is physically capable of later “no-return” meanings — uneven lava, caves, shallow soil, dense growth — but there is no twelfth-century evidence yet that it is publicly imagined as a suicide place. The raw material exists; the later discourse does not.

2. The main cultural object is Fuji, not Aokigahara

The twelfth-century sources do not give us a rich “Aokigahara” cultural record. They give us Fuji.

That distinction is essential. In later centuries, especially the twentieth, Aokigahara becomes the named object: 樹海, suicide forest, no-return place, media site. In the twelfth century, the named and documented transformation is Fuji’s religious reclassification.

Fujinomiya's official history says that around the twelfth century, as volcanic activity quietened, Fuji changed from a distant mountain feared for eruptions into a 修験道 training mountain, where practitioners entered the mountain to gain spiritual power.

 Fujinomiya City

Shizuoka's official page gives the same structure: in the late Heian period, after eruption activity calmed, Fuji became a Shugendō training ground combining older mountain worship with esoteric Buddhism and related religious ideas.

 Shizuoka Prefe...

That is the century's core change: **Fuji becomes enterable**.

Not Aokigahara as self-erasure. Fuji as ascetic access.

3. 1149: Matsudai Shōnin is the hard centre

The key twelfth-century date is 久安5年 / 1149.

The Shinshu University library exhibition summarises the *Honchō Seiki* entry: in 1149, Matsudai Shōnin built **Dainichi-ji / 大日寺** on Fuji's summit and sacred scriptures copied by Emperor Toba and aristocrats were dedicated there. The same source says Matsudai's activity marks the development of Fuji as a Shugendō training mountain.

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Kotobank, drawing on the older encyclopaedic tradition, identifies the *Honchō Seiki* entry for **1149, fourth month, sixteenth day** as the beginning of Fuji's Buddhist element: Matsudai is said to have built Dainichi-ji at the summit and buried/dedicated the complete Buddhist canon, becoming revered as the founder of Fuji Shugendō.  コトバンク

That is the most important twelfth-century source node. It gives us:

Matsudai;

1149;

summit;

Dainichi;

scripture dedication;

Buddhist sacralisation of Fuji;

Fuji Shugendō's beginning.

The deepest point: the twelfth-century sacred movement is **vertical**. Matsudai does not disappear into the forest. He ascends the mountain and installs Buddhist meaning at the summit.

4. Why Dainichi matters

Dainichi is not decorative. **Dainichi Nyorai / Mahāvairocana** is the cosmic Buddha central to esoteric Buddhism. Placing Dainichi-ji at the summit means Fuji is being read not

merely as a kami mountain, but as a Buddhist cosmic space.

Fujinomiya's account says that under the common medieval doctrine of 本地垂迹 / **honji-suijaku**, the summit was understood as a Buddhist world or as a place where buddhas appear in the form of kami; as a result, reaching the summit took on major religious significance.  Fujinomiya City

So the twelfth-century turn is not just “people started climbing”. It is: **the top of Fuji becomes a Buddhist destination.**

That is radically different from modern Aokigahara. Modern Aokigahara is not summit, temple, scripture, or return. It is forest entry, concealment, and non-return. The twelfth century is its structural opposite.

5. The mountain ceases to be only feared from below

Before this shift, Fuji's religious relation is heavily shaped by eruption fear and appeasement. Shizuoka's official page says people long feared Fuji's repeated eruptions as the dwelling of a god and established Sengen shrines at the foot to calm eruptions.

 Shizuoka Prefe...

By the twelfth century, that fear is not erased, but it is transformed. Once eruption activity quietens, religious specialists enter the mountain. Fujinomiya says Fuji becomes a site where Shugendō practitioners enter the mountain to perform austerities and gain spiritual power.  Fujinomiya City

That is the century's psychological hinge:

**from appeasing danger at the foot
to entering danger for power.**

This is the oldest deep structure that later matters for Aokigahara. Fuji nature is not neutral scenery. It is a place where ordinary human limits are crossed.

6. The body in the twelfth century: ordeal, not erasure

The modern Aokigahara body is imagined as becoming unfindable. The twelfth-century Fuji body is different. It climbs, suffers, performs austerity, and approaches a sacred summit.

The official Yamanashi guide describes the medieval Fuji of this period as a mountain where yamabushi performed severe practices after the terrifying eruptions quietened; it frames this as a solemn, profound Fuji faith centred on Buddhist and Shugendō practitioners.  Yamanashi Pref...

So if we are tracing “death” or “disappearance”, the answer is not suicide. It is **bodily extremity**. The body is put under strain because the mountain is religiously powerful.

The later forest of disappearance will secularise and invert this. But in the twelfth century, the point is not to stop existing. The point is to transform the body through religious ordeal.

7. The Omiya–Murayama route begins here, but is not yet the later mass route

The Omiya–Murayama route is the route-family most tied to Matsudai and early Fuji Shugendō. Yamanashi’s World Heritage page says the southern Fuji ascent from the Omiya/Murayama side began from Matsudai Shōnin’s activity in the twelfth century, while organised climbs by Shugendō practitioners are thought to have developed by the early fourteenth century.  【公式】富士の...

This is a useful precision point. The twelfth century supplies the **origin impulse**, not yet the full medieval mass pilgrimage apparatus.

The sequence is:

twelfth century — Matsudai and summit Buddhism;

thirteenth century — further cave/otherworld documentation, especially Hitoana in 1203;

fourteenth century — wider lay ascent, guides, lodging and route systems;

fifteenth/sixteenth centuries — fuller institutional expansion and Fuji-kō prehistory.

So the twelfth century is the ignition of **ascetic Fuji**, not yet the whole organised pilgrimage system.

8. Murayama: linked to Matsudai, but the hard institutional evidence is later

Murayama is important, but the dating must be kept clean.

Cultural Heritage Online says Murayama Sengen Shrine was traditionally founded by the twelfth-century ascetic Matsudai Shōnin and was known as **Kōhōji** / 興法寺, a syncretic religious facility; it also describes the site’s Dainichi hall, goma ritual space, water-purification area and later Shugendō objects.  Bunka Heritage...

Fujinomiya’s page is more cautious about the hard evidence: it says a temple is thought to have been established at Murayama in the Kamakura period by practitioners connected to Matsudai, and it notes a Dainichi Nyorai statue dated **1259**, which is outside the twelfth century.  Fujinomiya City

That matters. We can say:

Matsudai is the twelfth-century founding figure in the tradition. Murayama as a clearly evidenced institutional complex becomes firmer in later medieval material.

Do not overclaim a fully developed twelfth-century Murayama institution.

9. What is Aokigahara doing while this happens?

Physically, Aokigahara is sitting on the north-western lava flow. It is young, rough, forested, cave-bearing, and adjacent to the later Saiko/Shōjiko/Motosuko world. MLIT's Fuji Sabo page states the Aokigahara lava is visible under the forest and around those lake shores.



But culturally, the twelfth-century record we can cite does not make Aokigahara the central object. It is not yet the place where the documentary imagination goes. The sacred energy is going to:

summit;
Dainichi;
scripture;
Matsudai;
ascent;
Shugendō;
Buddhist-kami fusion.

Aokigahara is the **lava-foot background** to a mountain that is becoming spiritually enterable.

That is the exact relation.

10. No twelfth-century suicide-site evidence

This must be said plainly.

For the twelfth century, I find no reliable accessible evidence for:

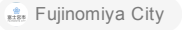
Aokigahara as a suicide destination;
Aokigahara as an ubasute site;
Aokigahara as a corpse forest;
Aokigahara as a named “樹海” death-discourse object;
people travelling there to disappear;
local records of repeated deaths in the forest;
a Matsumoto-like vanishing scene;
a no-return public reputation.

That is not a failure of imagination. It is the evidence.

The twelfth century gives **Fuji asceticism**, not Aokigahara suicide.

11. The century's death-relation: salvation and Buddhist world, not private disappearance

The “death” component in the twelfth century is indirect but deep. The summit becomes a Buddhist space. Dainichi-ji and sutra dedication imply that Fuji is being drawn into a soteriological world: karmic merit, sacred ascent, Buddhist protection, cosmic order.

Fujinomiya's source says that under honji-suijaku, the summit is recognised as a Buddhist world or a place where buddhas appear as kami, making the act of reaching the summit deeply meaningful. 

That is death-related because Buddhism is concerned with rebirth, salvation and liberation, but it is not suicidal. It is not “I want to vanish”. It is “I enter sacred order”.

So the twelfth-century grammar is:

approach death through salvation, not disappearance.

12. Directionality: the single most important distinction

The twelfth-century sacred movement is **up**.

Modern Aokigahara movement is **in**.

That sounds simple, but it is the whole historical distinction.

Twelfth century:

foot → slope → summit → Dainichi → Buddhist/kami world.

Modern Aokigahara:

road → forest edge → pathlessness → concealment → non-return.

One is vertical religious ascent. The other is horizontal secular disappearance.

The later Aokigahara myth becomes powerful partly because it takes the old Fuji act of leaving ordinary space and reverses its meaning. Instead of climbing toward cosmic visibility, one enters into social invisibility.

13. The twelfth century's “otherworld” is not yet the forest interior

The thirteenth century gives the Hitoana cave-underworld episode. The fourteenth and fifteenth centuries give more organised ascent. But the twelfth century's hard source centre is summit Buddhism.

That means the twelfth-century otherworld is not yet Aokigahara's dark interior. It is the **summit-as-Buddhist-world**.

Again, this matters because it prevents lazy continuity. The medieval Fuji otherworld does not map directly onto the modern suicide forest. It gives a deeper religious field, but the modern forest meaning is a later inversion.

14. What the twelfth century contributes to the later Aokigahara phenomenon

It contributes five preconditions, none of which is suicide.

First, **Fuji becomes enterable**. The mountain is no longer only feared from below; it becomes a space ascetics enter.  Fujinomiya City

Second, **Fuji's interior/topography becomes religiously charged**. The summit is not just a peak; it is a Buddhist/kami world.  Fujinomiya City

Third, **bodily hardship becomes meaningful**. The ascetic body can enter dangerous nature to obtain power, merit or transformation.  Yamanashi Pref...

Fourth, **text and authority sacralise the mountain**. Matsudai's 1149 act involves Dainichi-ji and sutra dedication, including aristocratic/imperial connection through Toba and copied scriptures.  Shinshu Univer...

Fifth, **the forest remains available as unclaimed background**. Because the twelfth-century focus is summit ascent rather than Aokigahara itself, the forest is not yet saturated with a specific public meaning. Later media can capture it more easily.

That fifth point is subtle but important: sometimes a place becomes available for later myth precisely because earlier systems did not fully fix it.

15. The “0.0000000001%” source here is not lurid — it is *Honchō Seiki*

For the twelfth century, the source that matters most is not a hidden ghost tale. It is the *Honchō Seiki* entry for 1149.

It gives the earliest hard pivot: Matsudai at Fuji's summit, Dainichi-ji, sutras, and the beginning of Fuji's Buddhist/Shugendō framing. Shinshu University's exhibition notes that the entry records Matsudai building Dainichi-ji and asking Emperor Toba to copy the *Daihannya-kyō* for dedication.  Shinshu Univer...

That is the deep source because it shows the exact moment Fuji's dangerous summit becomes a textual, Buddhist, aristocratically connected sacred space.

If we are tracing Aokigahara's later death-charge back as far as possible, this is one of the first medieval hinges: not because it mentions the forest, but because it changes what Fuji nature can mean.

16. The final twelfth-century thesis

In the twelfth century, Aokigahara is physically there but culturally secondary. It is a young lava forest on Fuji's north-west foot, formed on the 864–866 Aokigahara lava. The available twelfth-century cultural record does not treat it as a suicide place, corpse place, ubasute place, or "sea of trees" death-symbol.

The real twelfth-century transformation is Fuji's conversion into an ascetic Buddhist mountain. As eruptions quieten, practitioners enter the mountain. Matsudai Shōnin, recorded in the 1149 *Honchō Seiki* tradition, builds Dainichi-ji at the summit and connects Fuji to scripture, Dainichi, aristocratic patronage and Shugendō. The summit becomes a Buddhist/kami world. The body enters dangerous nature not to disappear, but to obtain religious power and transformation.

So the precise answer is:

The twelfth-century root of Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is not Aokigahara itself. It is the sacralisation of Fuji as enterable dangerous nature. The forest later inherits the prestige and dread of Fuji's non-ordinary terrain, but in the twelfth century the movement is vertical ascent to Dainichi, not horizontal disappearance into trees.

In one line:

Twelfth-century Fuji creates the religious grammar of entering dangerous nature; twentieth-century Aokigahara secularises that grammar into the fantasy of vanishing from society.